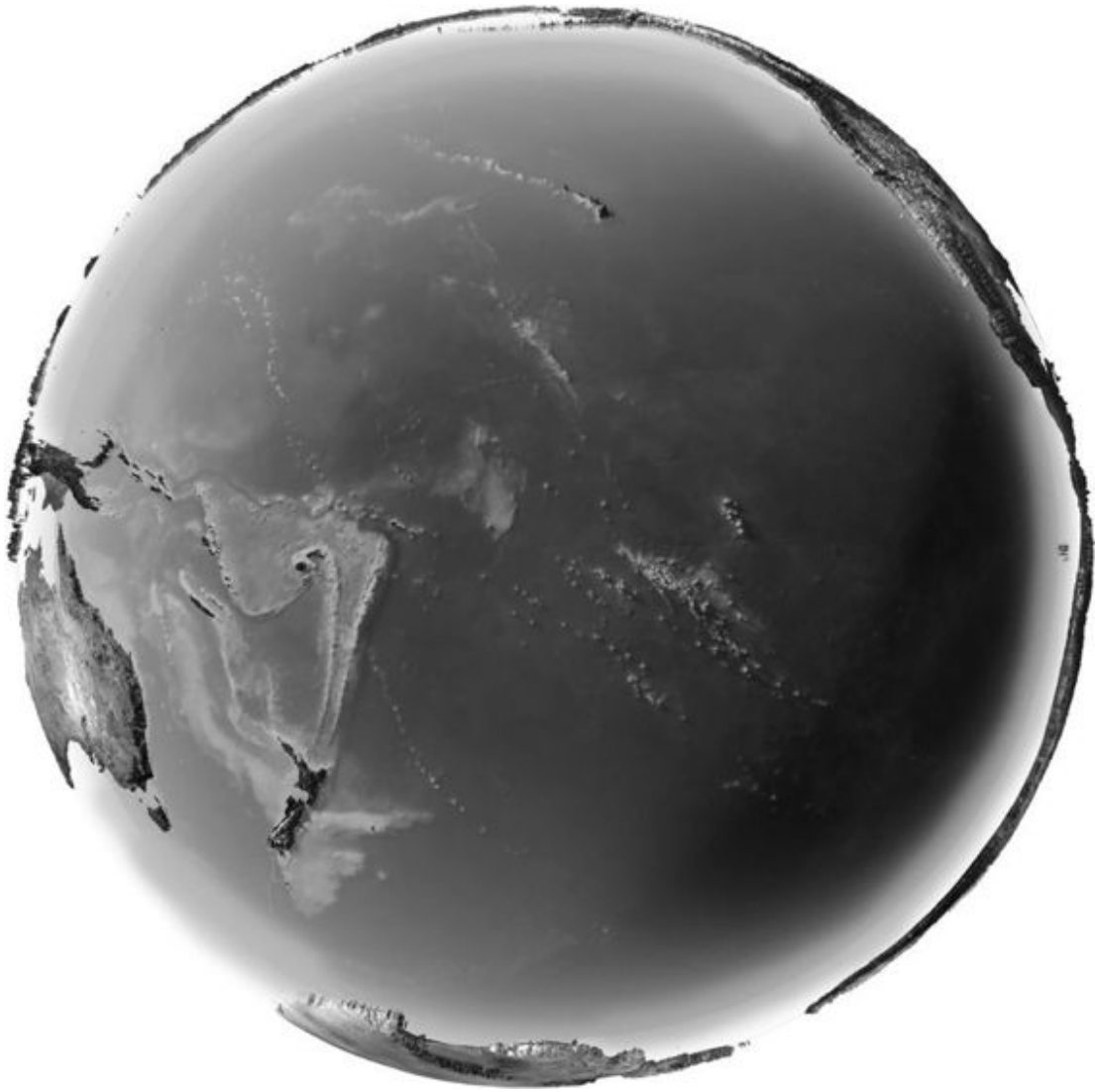


Thales of Miletus

Sometime around the beginning of the sixth century BCE in the Greek colony of Miletus, a man called Thales, dissatisfied with traditional explanations for the workings of the universe, sought to find his own answers by rational thought. As far as we know, he was the first to do this, and is considered to be the first philosopher. The problem that most concerned him, and became the abiding interest for all of the 'pre-Socratic' philosophers, was 'What is the world made of?'

Thales's answer was a surprising one: he believed everything was made from a single element: water. His reasoning was that water is essential to all life and appears in several forms – as well as a liquid, it is solid when cold, and a gas when hot. What's more, the solid earth seemed to be floating on water, so it probably emerged from water and was therefore made of water, as was everything in the universe. Thales idea was perhaps not as simplistic as it first seems, now modern science shows us that all matter can ultimately be reduced to energy.



Thales' cosmology took inspiration from the fact that much of Earth's surface is indeed covered by water.